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INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 23~07~2026

-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You

Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination. There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

NO ANY IMPORTANT ARTICLES FROM THE FRONTPAGE

IAF chief: Future wars can't be fought by individual Services

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, July 22

FUTURE WARS cannot be fought by individual services, but must be fought together as a unified nation to achieve success, Air Chief Marshal A P Singh said on Wednesday in Karwar during the commissioning ceremony of INS Malvan, the second vessel in the Mahe-class Anti-Submarine Warfare Shallow Water Craft (ASW-SWC) series.

He also underscored the need for developing military technologies at a faster pace, stating that "technology delayed is technology denied", and made a pitch for self-reliance in the aviation sector. The commissioning ceremony was attended by Vice Admiral Sanjay Vatsayan, Flag Officer Commanding-in-Chief, Western Naval Command; senior naval officers, veterans and representatives of state-run Cochin Shipyard Ltd.

Referring to INS Malvan, he said, "This ship and its crew carry forward the legacy of the erstwhile Malvan. I can see some stalwarts here from that ship, which served the nation with pride for decades until it was decommissioned in 2003." INS Malvan is the second of eight ASW-SWCs, being indigenously built by CSL, Kochi, and the sixth of 16 ASW-SWCs to be commissioned into the Navy. With over 80% indigenous content, the ship reinforces the Government's vision of Aatmanirbhar Bharat and India's expanding ecosystem of naval design, equipment, system integration, and growing self-reliance.



Air Chief Marshal Amar Preet Singh and Western Naval Command Flag Officer Commanding-in-Chief Vice Admiral Sanjay Vatsayan at the commissioning ceremony of INS Malvan on Wednesday. PTI

liance in defence shipbuilding.

The vessel is equipped for underwater surveillance, anti-submarine warfare (ASW) operations, and low-intensity maritime operations (LIMO), along with mine warfare capability. It will bolster coastal defence, littoral security, and enhance maritime domain awareness.

Highlighting the criticality of achieving jointness among the three services, particularly in fighting future wars, he said, "No future war is going to be fought by an individual service. All of us, whether we are in blues (IAF), whites (Navy), or OGs (Army), or whichever colour, whether we are in allied services, we all have to fight together as one nation, and then only we will succeed."

He mentioned that the growth of indigenous R&D (research and development) and production capabilities is encouraging, even as India has some distance to cover before reaching its targets. "If you have to grow and remain relevant, it

has to be at the speed of relevance. If you are growing at a speed that by the time you design and develop something, the world has moved over to a new technology, then that has no meaning. So according to me, any technology delayed is technology denied," he said.

He further said India's indigenous infrastructure is growing in terms of production; there is a big impetus which has been given. "I'm not saying we've reached somewhere very close to the target, but we are in the right direction, and as long as one is moving in the right direction, there is hope. I am sure if we don't waver from this path and remain focused, this will be a game changer," he said. Under the aegis of Project Seabird, Karwar has emerged as a symbol of India's maritime strategic vision and stands as one of the most modern naval bases globally.

Emphasising the significance of maritime security and maritime power for India's

growth, he stated that for any nation, maritime routes determine trade, and trade ultimately shapes destiny. "And as far as India is concerned, we all understand how important the Indian Ocean region is to us," adding that the Navy has been playing a vital role in securing sea lines of communication and ensuring that Indian trade and economic growth continue unhindered.

He stated that recent global developments have shown that no country can succeed without secure sea lines of communication and free trade. Referring to the Government's thrust on self-reliance, the Air Chief said the Navy had made significant progress in indigenous shipbuilding and expressed hope that the aviation sector would implement a similar model. "I just hope that the other two services, especially the Indian Air Force, learn the lesson as to how the Indian Navy has been able to get this whole concept right, where you have your Indian Navy officers who are embedded in your shipbuilding right from the beginning."

He further said that India was moving closer towards achieving self-reliance, even as some components still needed to be sourced or co-produced abroad, but those gaps would be bridged in due course.

INS Malvan derives its name from the historic coastal town of Malvan in Maharashtra, a region associated with the illustrious maritime heritage of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj. The vessel also encapsulates the legacy of her predecessor, an inshore Indian Naval Minesweeper that remained in service until 2003.

New Delhi, July 22

He added that the electorate in these constituencies reposed faith in Uddhav Thackeray's ideology and leadership. "The Lok Sabha elections in 2024

Meanwhile on Thursday, Senior Advocate Kapil Sibal told a bench presided by Chief Justice of India that he had also filed a petition raising the question of interpretation of the Tenth Schedule to the Constitution dealing with disqualification for defection.

With eye on China, Quad commits to strengthen 'free & open Indo-Pacific'

Foreign Minister stresses on ASEAN centrality, Rubio says Quad remains a priority for US

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 22

WITH AN eye on China's assertive behaviour in the region, the Quad foreign ministers committed to ASEAN's centrality and vowed to pursue peace and stability in the Indo-Pacific maritime domain.

This was one of the main takeaways from the Quad Foreign Ministers' Meeting in Manila on Wednesday, which was attended by External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, Australian Foreign Minister Penny Wong and Japan's Foreign Minister Toshimitsu Motegi.

After the meeting, Jaishankar posted on X: "Glad to participate in the Quad Foreign Ministers' Meeting in Manila. Reviewed the Indo-Pacific landscape and discussed recent developments. Followed up on the outcomes of the recent New



(From Left) Japan's Foreign Minister Toshimitsu Motegi, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio and Australian Foreign Minister Penny Wong during the Quad Foreign Ministers' Meeting in Manila on Wednesday. ANI

Delhi meeting. Committed to a free and open Indo-Pacific with a recognition of ASEAN centrality."

Rubio said, "Was pleased to reconvene the Quad at the @ASEAN Foreign Ministers' Meeting to emphasize our message: strong cooperation is vital to supporting ASEAN's own priority and centrality in the region."

"The United States, India, Australia, and Japan share a vision of a free and open Indo-Pacific that is grounded in the

rule of law, sovereignty, and territorial integrity. The Quad remains a priority, and we will meet again later this year," he said.

According to the joint statement issued after the Quad Foreign Ministers' Meeting, "As ASEAN Comprehensive Strategic Partners, we, the Secretary of State of the United States and the Foreign Ministers of Australia, India, and Japan, met today in Manila to reaffirm our commitment to strengthening a free and open

Indo-Pacific and our unwavering support for ASEAN unity and centrality."

"We are deeply invested in the region's success and in co-operating with ASEAN and its member states," it said.

"We discussed regional challenges and opportunities to strengthen our support for the practical implementation of the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific (AOIP) through our shared priorities of maritime and transnational security, economic prosperity and secur-

ity, critical and emerging technologies, and humanitarian assistance and emergency response," the statement said, adding: "We are united in our conviction that peace and stability in the Indo-Pacific maritime domain underpin the security and prosperity of the region."

The Japanese foreign ministry said the Quad meeting confirmed that the grouping will continue advancing "concrete cooperation" to realise a free and open Indo-Pacific that focuses on maritime and transnational security, economic prosperity and security.

Motegi said Wednesday's meeting sends a strong message that Quad is committed to promoting cooperation that benefits the region. "The four ministers confirmed that the Quad will continue to advance concrete cooperation to realise a Free and Open Indo-Pacific (FOIP)," a Japanese statement said. Motegi shared strong opposition to "any unilateral attempts to change the status quo by force or coercion and grave concerns over export restrictions, including on critical minerals, and emphasised the commitment to the complete denuclearisation of North Korea," the statement noted.

India underlines supply chain and market access with Wang

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 22

EXTERNAL AFFAIRS Minister S Jaishankar met Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi and conveyed India's concerns on "predictability of supply chain", "market access" and facilitating "official and people-to-people exchanges". He also underlined that "peace and tranquility in the border areas" is the prerequisite for normal ties — Delhi's position on the border standoff for the last six years.

Calling it a "wide-ranging conversation", Jaishankar — who met Wang on the sidelines of the East Asia and ASEAN foreign ministers' meetings — gave a broader context to the meeting: "We ourselves met a year ago and you were recently in India. Today's occasion will be useful in taking stock of our ties and also discussing important regional and global developments." Wang had visited India in June. Underlining the Indian approach towards engaging with China since the border standoff began in May 2020, Jaishankar said, "We believe that a stable and cooperative relationship can best be developed on the basis of mutual respect, mutual interest and mutual sensitivity. Such a relationship can make a valuable contribution to a multipolar Asia and a multipolar world."

"Peace and tranquility in the border areas is obviously the prerequisite for normal ties. Since October 2024, both sides have engaged to ensure that important objective. This will continue to need our constant attention. Relevant mechanisms in this domain must be given full support and strong encouragement," Jaishankar said. He referred to the India-



S Jaishankar with his Chinese counterpart Wang Yi. ANI

China agreement on disengagement, which was agreed in October 2024 and completed in November 2024.

In October 2024, India and China firmed up a disengagement pact for Depsang and Demchok, the last two friction points in eastern Ladakh. The two sides withdrew their troops from several friction points along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) in eastern Ladakh.

"Since the meeting of our leaders in Kazan in October 2024, relations between India and China have been gradually normalizing. This direction was further affirmed when they met in Tianjin last August," Jaishankar said.

Giving the overall strategic context, the External Affairs Minister said, "It is natural that as two large and important nations, and that too proximate neighbours, India and China would have their own particular interests. That is why our leaders had agreed that differences should not become disputes. It is the responsibility of diplomacy to properly manage them." He was flagging the Indian approach on "differences

E. EXPLAINED

Cementing ties, but challenges remain

IN AUGUST last year, at a bilateral meeting with Chinese President Xi Jinping on the sidelines of the SCO summit in Tianjin, PM Modi had said India is committed to taking forward its ties with China based on mutual trust, respect and sensitivity. Since then, while solid progress has been made, certain challenges remain, including the unresolved border issue.

should not become disputes" since the 2017 BRICS summit in Xiamen.

"The steps in normalization taken over the last few months must be welcomed. This includes resumption of direct flights, updating of the visa regime, restarting the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra, and re-commencing border trade," Jaishankar said.

Elaborating on the challenges the relationship is facing, he said, "However, there are also important dimensions of our ties that need to be addressed. Fair market access and a trade balance rank high in that regard. There are also concerns about predictability of supply chains. Facilitating both official and people-to-people exchanges merit our attention. We also need to agree on the meetings of various mechanisms and platforms as per our mutual priorities."

China overtook the US as India's largest trading partner in 2025–26, with total bilateral trade reaching \$151.1 billion.

Gujarat HC takes suo motu cognizance of police flogging, public parading of handcuffed accused

Aditi Raja
Vadodara, July 22

THE GUJARAT High Court has taken suo motu cognizance of the alleged police flogging and public parading of handcuffed accused in Surat, days after an advocate urged Chief Justice Sunita Agarwal to intervene in what he called a "disturbing and shocking" violation of constitutional guarantees. The Secretary, Home Department, has been arraigned as the respondent in the matter.

The action follows a representation made on July 14 by advocate Utkarsh Dave, who sought immediate judicial scrutiny of videos circulating on social media that allegedly show Surat Deputy Commissioner of Police Rajdeepsinh Nakum, accompanied by 15 to 20 police personnel, parading handcuffed accused persons on public roads and repeatedly assaulting them with lathis.

The representation alleges that the accused were "dragged by

their hair, slapped and beaten in full public view under the supervision of senior police officers."

Dave's representation to the Chief Justice describes the conduct as a "blatant violation" of Articles 14 and 21 of the Constitution, arguing that no police officer has the authority to punish an accused before trial, and that the power to investigate an offence cannot be converted into a licence for summary punishment or public humiliation. It draws on the Supreme Court's ruling in D K Basu vs. State of West Bengal, the foundational precedent on custodial safeguards, and cites the Gujarat High Court's own observations in the 2022 Kheda flogging case, where a similar public assault on accused persons drew judicial ire.

The representation also refers to the Gujarat Police's own departmental instructions prohibiting the public parading, humiliation and assault of accused persons.

● 'WATCH' ANTIBIOTICS ARE STRONGER MEDICINES MEANT TO BE RESERVED FOR CONDITIONS WHERE SIMPLER DRUGS MIGHT NOT WORK

India using too many powerful antibiotics meant for specific infections: Study

Anuradha Mascarenhas
New Delhi, July 22

INDIA MAY be using too many powerful 'watch' antibiotics — medicines that should be reserved for specific infections when simpler antibiotics are unlikely to work — while underusing both first-line 'access' antibiotics and last-resort 'reserve' drugs, according to a major international study published in *The Lancet Public Health*.

Researchers estimate that India's antibiotic use is skewed towards broader-spectrum drugs, suggesting that some patients are being exposed unnecessarily to 'watch' antibiotics even as others may not receive the most appropriate medicines for their infections. The findings come from the first global framework that estimates how much of

each category of antibiotics countries actually need based on their infection burden and antimicrobial resistance patterns.

The India findings are part of a wider global picture that shows nearly three-fourths of countries are using more antibiotics overall than needed, while almost every country is overusing the antibiotics that contribute most to antimicrobial resistance. At the same time, millions of people worldwide still lack access to the antibiotics they need.

"Our study found that in India some patients were exposed unnecessarily to antibiotics while others did not have access to the right antibiotics to treat their infections," Professor Ramanan Laxminarayan, founder and president of One Health Trust, senior research scholar at Princeton University

and one of the study's authors, told *The Indian Express*. "Strategies to improve antibiotic use will focus on ensuring populations have access to the right antibiotics at the right time while reducing unnecessary use."

How India map looks

The study estimates India would ideally require 14.7 defined daily doses (DID) of antibiotics per 1,000 people per day, comprising 7.8 DID of 'access' antibiotics, 6 DID of 'watch' antibiotics and 0.99 DID of 'reserve' antibiotics. Actual consumption, however, paints a different picture. India uses 18.3 DID overall, comprising 4.5 DID of 'access' antibiotics, 9.3 DID of 'watch' antibiotics and 0.19 DID of 'reserve' antibiotics. Only 27% of antibiotic use comes from the 'access category,' against an es-

What is antibiotic classification?

The World Health Organization (WHO) groups antibiotics into three categories:

- **ACCESS:** First-choice antibiotics for common infections that have a lower risk of driving resistance.
- **WATCH:** Broad-spectrum antibiotics that should be used only for specific infections because they carry a higher risk of promoting antimicrobial resistance.
- **RESERVE:** Last-resort antibiotics reserved for treating multidrug-resistant infections.

timated requirement of 52.3%.

"This suggests that in India some 'watch' antibiotics are potentially being used unnecessarily and some of this use could be replaced with 'access' antibiotics instead," Prof Laxminarayan says, adding India's higher burden of infectious diseases

and antimicrobial resistance means the country will legitimately require more 'watch' antibiotics than many other nations. However, the study also suggests 'reserve' antibiotics are being underused despite the nation's resistance burden, while antibiotics that are no longer rec-

ommended continue to be prescribed more than expected.

Prescribing pattern raises concerns

The findings mirror earlier evidence from India. The National Centre for Disease Control's First Multicentric Point Prevalence Survey of Antibiotic Use (2021-22), conducted across 20 tertiary care hospitals in 15 states and two UTs, found that nearly 3 out of every 4 hospitalised patients were receiving antibiotics. The survey showed 57% of prescriptions were for 'watch' antibiotics, 38% were 'access' antibiotics and 2% were 'reserve' antibiotics. About 3% were fixed-dose combinations not recommended by WHO.

Only 6% of antibiotic prescriptions were based on microbiological evidence, with

most antibiotics started without culture confirmation.

Dr Kamini Wallia, Programme Officer (AMR) and Head of the Division of Descriptive Research at ICMR, who was present at the study, says more than half (55%) of antibiotic prescriptions were for prophylaxis rather than treatment, suggesting opportunities to improve surgical prophylaxis, perioperative antibiotic policies and infection prevention practices.

She highlights unnecessary duplicate antibiotic coverage, noting that 26.4% of prescriptions included duplicate gram-negative coverage and 8.7% duplicate anaerobic coverage, increasing toxicity, costs and the risk of antimicrobial resistance without improving outcomes.

Another concern was the

extensive use of injectable antibiotics, with 86.5% administered intravenously, alongside wide variation in prescribing practices across hospitals, where antibiotic use ranged from 37% to 100%.

According to Dr Wallia, India should particularly focus on reducing unnecessary use of commonly prescribed 'watch' antibiotics such as ceftriaxone, cefixime, azithromycin, ciprofloxacin, levofloxacin and piperacillin-tazobactam through better antimicrobial stewardship and awareness.

'Reserve' antibiotics, including meropenem, colistin, ceftazidime-avibactam, cefiderocol and aztreonam-avibactam, should be restricted to patients with documented or strongly suspected multidrug-resistant infections.

NUMBER OF AFFECTED PEOPLE CLIMBED FROM 3.6 LAKH TO 5.6 LAKH IN JUST ONE DAY, SAY AUTHORITIES

‘Whole village went under water’: Assam grapples with floods, 21 dead in 24 hours

Sukrita Baruah
Guwahati, July 22

THROUGH A long and sleepless night, Prasanta Borthakur’s family, including his 95-year-old father, spent hours perched on chairs they had placed on their beds as flood waters entered their house in Nazira, in Assam’s Sivasagar district.

The water had begun to rise rapidly between 5 pm and 7 pm on Sunday evening, and soon, it had entered their home in the Rajapul area and rose up to their chests. After sending out frantic calls and distress messages through the evening and night, a National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) team reached them on a boat on Monday morning and evacuated them.

“Ours is the highest house in Rajapul, and till date, we have never had water enter our house. Forget in my lifetime, my father said that he has never seen such flooding in his 95 years. Our whole village went underwater, and everybody spent their night like us, or on the roofs of their houses, or even on trees,” said 50-year-old Borthakur.

What unfolded in their village over Sunday and Monday was only the start of days of unprecedented flooding across the Upper Assam districts of Sivasagar, Charaideo, Jorhat and Golaghat. The flooding has



People cross a flood-affected area on a makeshift raft after heavy rainfall in Golaghat on Wednesday. PTI

been spreading to new areas of the region every day, and has claimed 27 lives so far. Within a span of 24 hours on Monday, 21 people lost their lives.

According to estimates by the Assam State Disaster Management Authority, the number of people affected by the floods rose from 3.6 lakh on Monday to 5.6 lakh on Tuesday, signalling the rapid deterioration of the situation.

As of Tuesday night, a total of 6,101 people were evacuated

by boats, with 5,764 of them being from Sivasagar. As many as 12,284 people were staying in relief camps across seven districts of Assam.

Floods inundate vast swathes of Assam every year, displacing lakhs of people. But the floods currently engulfing parts of Upper Assam are unprecedented in this belt, which does not usually experience this magnitude of flooding as it is located considerably inland from the banks of the

Brahmaputra.

This time, the Brahmaputra’s tributaries running through these districts, such as the Dikhow, Disang and Janji, have swelled up and inundated large swathes of the region.

By Tuesday evening and on Wednesday, the floods had reached Sivasagar town and rose up to waist level.

“I have never in my life seen this kind of flooding here,” said 53-year-old Nasimuddin Ahmen, who works in a govern-

ment office in the town.

“The small river, Darika, which flows a few kilometres from the town, has now overflowed. Every year when it rains, there is some waterlogging, but this is the first time that the river has reached the town. It has reached my backyard, and I have not been able to step out of home today,” he said.

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma has attributed the floods in the region to a “cloudburst” in Nagaland’s Mon district, which is located upstream from these tributaries. He had earlier said that the floods had resulted in “water levels unseen in half a century”.

A scientist at the Meteorological Centre in Kohima said the rainfall in Mon does not technically qualify as a cloudburst, which the IMD defines as rainfall exceeding 100 mm within one hour. However, the district did experience a heavy spell of over 130 mm rainfall on Sunday.

“On Sunday, we had 137 mm of rainfall in Mon, which took place over a period of eight to nine hours. What happened is that in the 15-20 days before it, it received three-four spells of heavy rainfall, because of which the mountains were already saturated with water. The spell that took place on Sunday then triggered this,” he said.

Mon itself was devastated by the rainfall, with nine people

losing their lives to landslides.

With the Opposition questioning the government over its preparedness for these floods, including in the Legislative Assembly on Wednesday, the government has maintained that “no one could be prepared” for what ministers have described as a “calamity”.

Minister of Water Resources Susanta Borgohain told The Indian Express: “We have not had this kind of situation here earlier. The amount of rain released in Nagaland all went down to the foothill areas of Charaideo and Nazira. There has not been a breach of embankments. Instead, the water levels have completely overtopped them (meaning the water levels have crossed the tops of the embankments). And now it is draining towards the Brahmaputra in an unorthodox route, moving towards it not only through the tributaries but over free land.”

The NDRF, the State Disaster Response Force (SDRF), the Indian Army, district administrations and Fire and Emergency Services have all been pressed into rescue and relief work. According to officials, helicopters are also being used to airdrop supplies to areas that are currently inaccessible even by boat. They said that on Wednesday, drones have also begun to be used for the purpose.

Ken-Betwa rehab: MP govt vows inquiry into complaints

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, July 22

THE MADHYA Pradesh government on Tuesday said there would be an inquiry into complaints surrounding the rehabilitation of families displaced by the Rs 44,605-crore Ken-Betwa Link Project, after Leader of Opposition Umang Singhar alleged large-scale irregularities in compensation, rehabilitation surveys and Gram Sabha proceedings during a heated exchange in the Assembly.

Replying to Singhar’s questions, Revenue Minister Karan Singh Verma maintained that almost all affected families had been compensated under the rehabilitation package and denied any scam. However, Chief Minister Mohan Yadav intervened to assure the House that any complaint brought before the government would be investigated and promised to complete the exercise within a month.

“If you are aware of any discrepancy or complaint, we will



Villagers from the submergence zone of the dam sit on a protest by the banks of the Ken. EXPRESS

certainly investigate it and do justice to them. No one should suffer under our government,” Yadav said. When Singhar sought a timeline, citing ongoing construction and police action against protesters, the CM replied that the matter would be resolved “within a month”.

The debate centred on rehabilitation under the Ken-Betwa Link Project, India’s first inter-basin river-linking project,

which proposes to transfer water from the Ken River in Madhya Pradesh to the Betwa River flowing into Uttar Pradesh. The project is expected to irrigate over nine lakh hectares, supply drinking water across Bundelkhand and generate hydropower, but it also requires the acquisition of land and displacement of thousands of families in Panna and Chhatarpur districts.

According to the govern-

ment’s written reply, 1,321 families across seven villages in Panna district have been displaced, while 3,718 families in 14 villages of Chhatarpur district have been affected by land acquisition or submergence. The government stated that all affected families had been sanctioned compensation and rehabilitation benefits.

However, it also acknowledged that complaints had been received regarding omissions from rehabilitation lists and compensation disputes. In Chhatarpur, the government said village-wise survey teams were constituted through an office order issued on April 15, 2026. Following the resurvey, 638 additional eligible families were found and sanctioned rehabilitation benefits, taking the total number of beneficiaries from 3,080 to 3,718 families.

In Panna, the government said a fresh survey was also conducted after complaints regarding omitted beneficiaries and compensation assessment, but

maintained that no eligible person had ultimately been left out and no irregularities were found.

Singhar questioned these claims, asking the government to table the survey reports and Gram Sabha proceedings before the Assembly.

“The government says everyone has received compensation, yet you yourself are saying some families are still pending. Will you table the survey report? Will you table the Gram Sabha proceedings?” he asked.

Verma agreed to place the records before the House as directed by the Chair.

The rehabilitation process has been at the centre of protests in the project area for months. Villagers in Daudhan, Palkhua, Sukwaha and other affected villages have repeatedly alleged that eligible family members were left out of surveys, compensation assessments were incorrect and rehabilitation benefits were unevenly distributed.

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Trade deals need to be set in strategy, not expediency



SRINATH SRIDHARAN

DEAR EDITOR I disagree

A fortnightly column in which we invite readers to tell us why, when they differ with the editorial positions or news coverage of 'The Indian Express'

India should eliminate exploitative labour practices because they weaken our economy, diminish our reputation and betray our own values, not because another country expects it

A RECENT editorial in this newspaper argued that a deal with the United States now will go a long way in reducing the uncertainty that has marred relations between the countries, while expanding trade ('Ahead of the big deal, strike a careful balance', *IE*, July 17). But the proposed India-United States trade agreement is about far more than trade. It is about how a rising India engages the world's largest economy while preserving the strategic confidence, policy flexibility and institutional freedom that will define its next phase of growth.

Even after agreements with the UK, Australia and Europe, no market matches the scale, investment capacity, technological depth and strategic importance of the US. Equally, America has strong reasons to deepen its economic engagement with India. It seeks access to one of the world's fastest-growing consumer markets, a trusted strategic partner in an uncertain Indo-Pacific and an economy that will shape demand for digital and financial services. Neither country can fully realise its ambitions without a deeper partnership with the other.

Washington may also have underestimated India by assuming that the goodwill and political symbolism of the Howdy Modi moment would translate into greater negotiating flexibility and acceptance of US preferences in a bilateral agreement. It did not. Tariffs, public pressure and shifting geopolitical signals may have tested the relationship, but they did not fundamentally alter India's negotiating posture, reminding both capitals that political chemistry has its limits, whereas sound public policy demands pragmatism, reciprocity and an unwavering commitment to long-term interests.

That is precisely why these negotiations deserve greater public reflection. The pursuit of immediate economic gain, or the political satisfaction of announcing a successful agreement, could gradually narrow the policy choices available to future governments. Every bilateral negotiation requires accommodation. None should diminish a nation's long-term strategic confidence.

Diplomatic engagement has become more transactional and, on occasion, un-

comfortably patronising. Tariffs, sanctions, export controls, technology restrictions and financial access have become instruments of geopolitical influence. India has navigated these changes with composure. That composure should continue, but New Delhi must remain anchored in strategic judgment rather than tactical expediency.

The commitments India accepts today may well become the standards the US expects from it and others tomorrow. Trade agreements increasingly establish geopolitical precedents, not merely commercial obligations. That is why every clause deserves to be negotiated with an eye on the next decade rather than the next news cycle. The concerns over forced labour should also prompt introspection, not indignation. India should eliminate exploitative labour practices because they weaken our economy, diminish our reputation and betray our own values, not because another country expects it.

Equal care is required in areas extending beyond merchandise trade. Labour mobility, digital trade, data governance, and emerging technologies will shape India's development long after tariff schedules are forgotten. The defining lesson of contemporary geopolitics is unmistakable: Technology that a nation does not own can, one day, be used to influence, constrain or coerce it. Trade agreements must preserve India's sovereign ability to govern its data, regulate its digital economy and shape its technological future. The same discipline should guide India's approach to food and energy security.

Agreements of this consequence acquire greater durability and public confidence when subjected to scrutiny before becoming binding national commitments. Such scrutiny strengthens international agreements by giving them wider political ownership and democratic legitimacy. The understandable desire to conclude an agreement within a political timetable should never outweigh the responsibility of preserving India's long-term strategic choices. We should negotiate for the economy we aspire to become, not merely the economy we happen to be.

Sridharan is a corporate advisor and author of *Family and Dhanda*

The Ideas Page

THURSDAY, JULY 23, 2026

Science thrives on a global outlook, an inclusive culture. FCRA makes it difficult



VIKRAM PATEL

SUCCESSIVE GOVERNMENTS have proclaimed their vision for India to become a powerhouse of scientific research. The current NDA regime has launched new initiatives to catalyse the science ecosystem — these include the Anusandhan National Research Foundation, the introduction of national rankings of research institutions, and the institution of fellowships to attract diaspora scientists to work in Indian institutions. However, India continues to be a laggard amongst its peer nations in high-impact research productivity. None of the country's institutions figures in the top 100 of any global ranking. Many of our brightest minds continue to seek opportunities abroad, and the work of scientists is powering the rankings of their adopted institutions and, by extension, the countries in which they are located. The success of the national science ecosystem requires not just the talent of individual researchers but also a global outlook and an inclusive culture. At the heart of such an ecosystem is collaboration and partnerships between institutions within and across countries. The Foreign Contribution Regulation Act (FCRA) has been a singular obstacle to India's science ecosystem.

First, a bit of history. The Act's genesis lies in the late 1960s, when the government suspected foreign agencies, such as the CIA, of funding trade unions, student bodies, and political organisations to undermine India's democracy. This prompted the then home minister to raise the issue in Parliament in 1969, leading to a consensus that foreign money should not be allowed to undermine the state behind the mask of charity. After due parliamentary process, the FCRA came into force on August 5, 1976 — it aimed to ensure that voluntary organisations functioned “in a manner consistent with the values of a sovereign democratic republic”. Since then, successive govern-

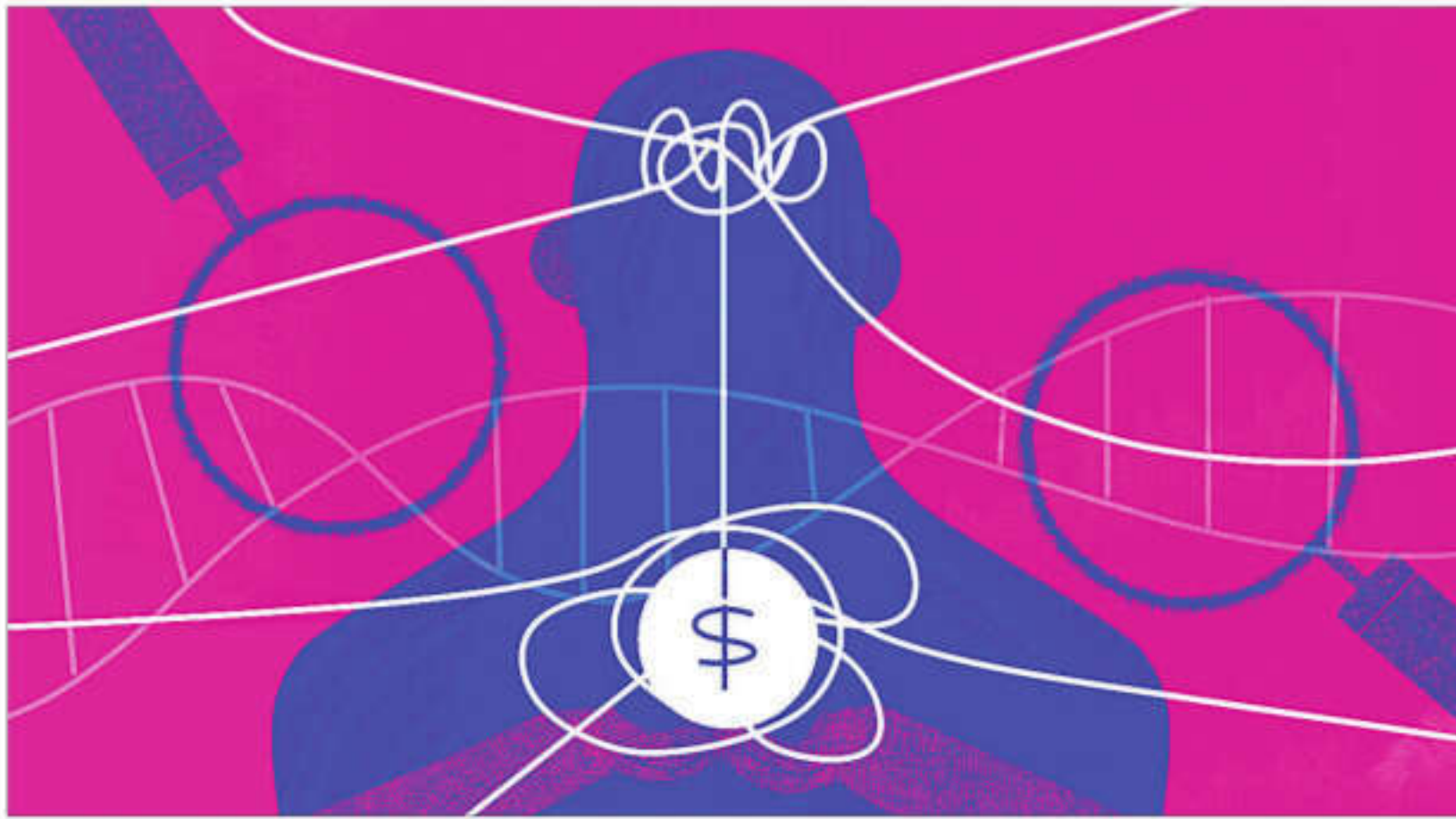


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

ments have tightened the regulations through multiple amendments, culminating in the most recent ones, which have ramped up the regulatory compliance for NGOs and amplified the powers of the state to terminate FCRA approval and seize the assets of organisations. It is not my intention in this article to question the rationale or legality of the FCRA, but to highlight how the FCRA, from its inception, has been throttling the work of NGOs whose work is related to science.

Readers may wonder what NGOs have to do with science in the first place. After all, many of us think of NGOs as primarily concerned with the provision of services such as education or healthcare or promoting rights-based activities (the latter being, unsurprisingly, the most sensitive sector for governments). I believe that those formulating the FCRA rules in government don't seem to recognise that many globally renowned research institutions in India are categorised as NGOs and, as such, fall under the purview of the FCRA. Examples include both institutes which have diverse scientific portfolios such as the Public Health Foundation of India, Christian Medical College (Vellore), St John's

In the case of NGOs engaged in scientific activities, this role can be readily identified through existing regulatory procedures, and FCRA rules can be tailor-made for this sector

Medical College, Ashoka and KREA universities, as well as niche institutions that work in specific fields such as Sangath, the Schizophrenia Research Foundation and the Centre for Mental Health, Law and Policy in the mental health field; the Centre for Chronic Disease Control and Dr Mohan's Diabetes Centre in the non-communicable diseases field; and M S Swaminathan Research Foundation and ATREE in biodiversity and environmental science. This vast and diverse ecosystem is, perhaps inadvertently, experiencing collateral damage from regulations designed to prevent foreign interference in India's democratic polity in multiple ways, not least through strangling the opportunity for these institutions to collaborate internationally and with each other in the country.

I offer two concrete examples to illustrate these observations. The first is the rule that foreign funds received by an NGO in India can never be repatriated out of the country. This regulation flies in the face of the reasonable requirement by international funders that unspent funds from a research project must be returned upon completion of a project. But, even more worryingly, it also means that no Indian NGO can

ever be the lead institution in an international collaboration because it cannot fulfil the obligations of a lead institution to transfer funds from the parent grant to a foreign institution. The second example is the 2020 change to the FCRA, which stopped NGOs receiving foreign donations from sharing those funds with any other NGO in India, even those legally registered to receive foreign funding. This was a deliberate shift from a “regulated transfer” model to an outright prohibition on sub-granting. In effect, this meant a shutdown of collaboration within the country, not only hurting smaller, grassroots NGOs that historically relied on larger NGOs re-granting foreign funds to them, but also hindering science, which requires engagement with communities, as is the case with many studies concerned with health and development.

It is important to note that the source of the funds for NGOs working on scientific endeavours are not donations but grants from renowned international research bodies such as the Wellcome Trust or the National Institutes of Health. These are hard-earned in globally competitive bids with selection through a transparent process of peer review; it is for this reason that such awards are highly prized by institutions such as mine because they reflect world-class scientific minds. In India, on the other hand, instead of honour and prestige, such foreign grants are viewed with suspicion.

There is an easy remedy to this matter — to bring nuance into the classification of NGOs in India and recognise the immense diversity of the roles that they play. In the case of NGOs engaged in scientific activities, this role can be readily identified through existing regulatory procedures such as recognition by the Department of Scientific and Industrial Research, and FCRA rules can be tailor-made for this sector of NGOs. Such a measured strategy would not undermine the goal of the government to regulate the NGO sector. At the same time, it would also not cause collateral harm to the globally renowned institutional ecosystem for science in India.

The writer is the Paul Farmer Professor at Harvard Medical School and co-founder of Sangath, which works on mental health



SUSHANT KUMAR

ON JULY 14, New York became the first US state to halt construction of large new data centres, imposing a one-year moratorium as concerns grew that the facilities were raising power costs, straining water supplies and burdening local communities. Massachusetts Governor Maura Healey, too, announced that her administration would pause accepting data centre sales tax exemption applications until stronger protections are in place for Massachusetts residents, businesses and communities. Her administration is also releasing a comprehensive framework to guide responsible data-centre development to ensure projects do not drive up energy costs, strain local infrastructure or harm public health and the environment.

In the first quarter of 2026, local opposition groups all over the US blocked or delayed 75 separate data-centre projects worth an estimated \$130 billion. Other countries have followed suit. The city of Amsterdam, Netherlands, barred new data centres or expansions until at least 2030. The Dutch national government's 2022 hyperscale ban restricts large facilities to just two designated locations nationally. Singapore enforced an absolute moratorium on new data-centre construction between 2019 and 2022, replaced later by a highly restricted, competitive quota system under the Green Data Centre Roadmap. Ireland's grid operator effectively blocked new data centre con-

India's AI data-centre market, currently at \$5.5 billion and about 1.6 GW capacity, is set to rise to \$90 billion and about 12-14 GW capacity by 2035

AI future needs responsible data-centre regulation

nections around Dublin from 2021 after warnings the facilities were straining the grid. The freeze ended in December 2025, with new connections now required to bring their own on-site power generation.

In India, there is hardly any critical political discourse on responsible development of AI data centres except in lofty vision papers. On the ground, India is actively incentivising expansion. In UP, the Data Centre Policy 2021 offers capital subsidies and 100 per cent stamp duty exemption on land, electricity duty exemption reducing operating costs, land in dedicated data centre parks at concessional rates, and a single-window clearance system enabling fast approvals for large investors. In Tamil Nadu, similar policies provide for subsidised land in industrial parks, 100 per cent electricity duty exemption, and tax reimbursements linked to investment. In Telangana, the government allocates land in IT corridors, provides power subsidies and dedicated electricity infrastructure, and ensures fast-track approval.

India is the most water-stressed among the top 10 data-centre hosting countries. According to one report, a Yotta Data Centre located in Uttar Pradesh has led to a decline in the groundwater table from 30 m to 180-250 m, pushing people into the hands of private vendors. Additionally, these data centres have hardly created any long-term permanent jobs, except for housekeeping or gatekeeping. Unlike factories of the industrial

era, data centres are not labour-intensive. They can be run by very few employees, mostly high-level, once fully functional. So, any promise of bringing jobs and prosperity to the country should be measured against the land, power and water they consume.

India's AI data-centre market, currently at \$5.5 billion and about 1.6 GW capacity, is set to rise to \$90 billion and about 12-14 GW capacity by 2035. Reliance is partnering with Meta, the Adani Group is partnering with Google and other tech giants, and Tata is collaborating with OpenAI to develop some of the major upcoming infrastructure.

Even as definitive evidence on return on investment from AI in business processes remains inconclusive, the short-term costs of the technology are becoming clearer, often borne by local communities while profits go to national and global corporations. There are also concerns about who would bear the cost if these massive, largely debt-funded, data centres turn into the ghost infrastructure of tomorrow should the AI bubble burst.

India hosts 20 per cent of the world's data but has only about 3 per cent of the world's data centres — a key reason for the aggressive expansion. This only calls for more cautious governance frameworks before harms to local communities are normalised. India can demonstrate global leadership in AI by taking steps to regulate these hyperscalers.

The writer is assistant professor and assistant dean, Jindal School of Government and Public Policy

Tax exemption based on marriage, relation: Centre opposes same-sex couple’s petition

Mustafa Plumber
Bengaluru July 22

THE UNION government Wednesday opposed a petition filed by a same-sex couple seeking to declare the term ‘spouse’ as defined in the Income Tax Act as unconstitutional, by saying that the term ‘relative’.

Appearing for the Centre, Additional Solicitor General Aravind Kamath argued, “The relatives are not classified on the basis of sex; they are classified on the basis of either a legally defined marital relationship or a direct family relationship. It is not based on sex, as wrongly misunderstood by the petitioners.”

As per Section 56(2)(x) of the Income Tax Act, any money or property worth more than Rs

50,000 received without consideration is taxable as “income from other sources”. The proviso carves out gifts received from a “relative” — a term defined to include the “spouse of the individual”

Kamath discussed the definition of ‘relative’ as outlined in clause vii of Section 56(2) of the Act regarding who can claim tax exemption on gifts received.

“It is based on a legally verifiable family relationship called marriage for which the parliament has separate law and direct family status like—a sibling, so that if there is a dispute of a particular transfer of property, it can be verified by the authority with least intrusion into the status of the relative.”

Stating that petitioners, Anurag Kalia and Akhilesh Godi in their plea claim to be in a stable relationship, Kamath argued, “What is meant by it (stable relationship), can an assessing officer inquire into it.”

“Which is why Parliament has confined the relationship to legally verifiable relationships like marriage and blood relations which can be easily verified with least intrusion into the status.”

Justice B M Shyam Prasad orally said, “Your submission is that Parliament in its wisdom has carved out the exception so that nobody abuses it and it is to ensure that specific relationships are elaborately defined on the basis of verifiable legal status either by marriage or by blood. Today, if we read down

the provision, we will introduce uncertainty.”

Advocate Dhruv Janssen-Sanghavi, who appears for the couple, has earlier argued that they are not saying that the use of the term spouse is unconstitutional, but rather the reference to the term spouse refers to an indirect discrimination.

Sanghavi had argued that there is no genetic relationship between the two petitioners; the relationship between them is conjugal. The use of the word spouse reserves an indirect discrimination, which excludes the petitioners and denies them the equal protection of the law. Further, the petition states that they seek neither recognition nor presumption of marriage, nor any declaration of marital status.

The petitioners, who work as software engineers in Bengaluru, have told the court that they have been together for more than seven years, cohabiting since 2019 with a jointly owned house in the city.

The dispute began with a 22-karat gold bracelet weighing 14.41 grams and valued at Rs 1,15,500. Godi gifted it to Kalia

Had the two men been a married couple, or even an unmarried heterosexual couple presumed to be married by virtue of long cohabitation, the bracelet would not have counted as income at all, and would not even have had to be disclosed in a tax return.

Instead, while preparing his returns for 2025-26, Kalia was advised that he must have the bracelet valued by a registered

valuer, report its fair market value as income, and pay tax on it at 25 per cent, plus a 15 per cent surcharge and 4 per cent cess, according to their petition. Thus they moved the court seeking to declare the provision as unconstitutional.

The plea states that a heterosexual couple in the petitioners’ circumstances would therefore qualify as “spouses”, and hence “relatives”, under the tax exemption.

The petitioners argued that they are denied the same benefit “solely on the basis of sex”, in violation of Articles 14 and 15 of the Constitution, with consequent violations of Articles 19(1)(a) and 21, by taxing “an expression of love and affection”.

The court will continue hearing the plea on August 4.

NEW DELHI HAS BEEN AGAINST PLURILATERAL AGREEMENTS ON E-COMMERCE AND INVESTMENTS

India & key WTO members remain at loggerhead on plurilateral pacts

Plurilateral agreements are negotiated and implemented by exclusive groups rather than by all members of WTO

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, July 22

AS INDIA remains among the few large countries opposing plurilateral agreements on e-commerce and investments, a group of countries across developed and developing nations blocks such as EU, Canada, UK, Cambodia and Gambia on Tuesday questioned its approach, alleging that New Delhi was holding up the WTO reform process, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Questions were raised during India's trade policy review, which happens once every five years. An Indian delegation led by Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal presented details on India's reforms to WTO members.

Plurilateral agreements, which are negotiated and implemented by exclusive groups rather than by all members, have begun being featured prominently in various World Trade Organisation (WTO) reform-related proposals.

India, meanwhile, maintained that plurilateral agreements were against the core WTO principle of consensus-based decision-making process. Major trading powers like the US, EU and China are backing plurilateral negotiations, where benefits and responsibilities

would be limited to the signatory members.

While Canada most prominently opposed India's stand on plurilateral agreements, the EU said that over the past decade, India has benefitted significantly from its integration into global trade and has increased its share in world trade.

"The EU encourages India to rethink its approach to plurilateral agreements and to consider them as an opportunity to shape the agenda of the WTO and to modernise the organisation rather than as a threat to multilateralism — which they are not, if we build them properly," the EU representative said in the internal meeting as per sources.

While Gambia and Costa Rica asked India to withdraw its opposition to the Investment Facilitation for Development (IFD) agreement, several countries asked India to join negotiations for plurilateral agreements such as the fossil fuels subsidy reform initiative, dialogue on plastics pollution and environmentally sustainable plastics trade.

As many as 129 members have supported IFD, but India remains the primary holdout, citing systemic risks and stating that investment is not a core trade issue.



Questions were raised during India's trade policy review, which happens once every five years. REUTERS

An international trade expert, who did not wish to be named, said that after the proponents of e-commerce plurilaterals failed in their attempts during MC14, they tried a new strategy by trying to have interim arrangements on e-commerce without following WTO rules.

They made WTO DG Ngozi Okonjo-Iweala the depositary of the interim arrangements, and India has rightly challenged this arrangement, as this agreement makes a "mockery" of the rules, the expert said.

In a July 9 letter to the WTO, India questioned the "legal basis" under which the WTO DG was assigned the role to act as the "depositary of the Agreement on Electronic Commerce (ECA)".

"The Marrakesh Agree-

ment requires consensus to add an Agreement to Annex 4. Consensus was not reached on two occasions. In the absence of consensus, we would like to understand the institutional basis on which the Interim Arrangements are operating," India said.

As per the WTO, 66 members, covering approximately 70% of global trade, have adopted a pathway to bring into force the WTO Agreement on Electronic Commerce through "interim arrangements" while continuing to work towards its incorporation into the WTO legal framework of rules.

The E-Commerce Agreement prohibits the imposition of customs duties on electronic transmissions between a person of one party and a person of another party.

India's stand against plurilateral pacts

During the 14th Ministerial Conference (MC14) in Yaoundé, Cameroon, India was the only country opposing IFD's incorporation into the WTO framework as an Annex 4 Agreement. Annex 4 of the Marrakesh Agreement contains the Plurilateral Trade Agreements, and unlike multilateral agreements that bind all 164 WTO member states, these agreements are only legally binding on the specific members that voluntarily sign and accept them

Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal in March said that incorporation of the IFD agreement risks eroding the functional limits of the WTO and undermining its foundational principles. "At WTO MC14, drawing inspiration from Mahatma Gandhi ji's philosophy of truth prevailing over conformity, India showed the courage to stand alone on the contentious issue of the IFD Agreement and did not agree to its incorporation into the WTO framework as an Annex 4 Agreement," Goyal said. "Despite a challenging global environment, India has remained the world's fastest-growing major economy, achieved record exports, accelerated digital transformation, strengthened innovation and improved the ease of doing business," Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said in a social media post on Tuesday.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

RESERVE BANK OF INDIA'S 'STATE OF ECONOMY' REPORT

'Foreign inflow revival reflects confidence in Indian economy'

George Mathew
Mumbai, July 22

THE REVIVAL of foreign investment in recent months reflects renewed confidence in the economy, despite the ongoing conflict in West Asia and elevated crude oil prices, according to a study by the Reserve Bank of India.

"The global economy is dealing with an uncertain economic environment, supply chain disruptions, and fragmented trading relationships," the 'State of the Economy' article in the RBI monthly bulletin said. "Amidst these uncertainties, India remains among the fastest growing major economies across the globe and has been able to sustain the momentum in economic activities through June. Both industrial and services sector indicators remained firm," the article authored by RBI researchers said. Foreign portfolio outflows have tapered off and the markets witnessed inflows in the recent past.

The RBI article said the farm sector is witnessing uneven southwest monsoon, but the impact on food inflation may be mitigated by comfortable foodgrain stocks. "The momentum of external trade sus-

RBI sells \$6.1 billion forex in May

Mumbai: The Reserve Bank of India sold a net \$6.1 billion in the foreign exchange market in May, data released on Wednesday showed.

This follows a sharp rise in oil prices due to the Iran war

pushed the rupee to an all-time low. It purchased \$22.2 billion and sold \$28.3 billion in May. In April, the central bank had sold a net \$8.9 billion, the RBI said in its monthly bulletin on Wednesday. **ENS**

tained as reflected in high growth in exports and imports in Q1 of 2026-27," it said.

"This is likely to be strengthened by the recent operationalisation of the India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement and progress in other bilateral trade agreements. External vulnerability indicators also remained sound. Recovery of foreign investments in recent months shows a revival of confidence in the economy," it said. The global economy is continuing with the heightened uncertainties emanating from fragile geopolitics and supply chain pressures, the article said. The domestic economy has navigated the external uncertainties well, underpinned by healthy demand conditions and resilient performance of the industrial and services sector. "Headline retail

inflation inched up in June while core inflation, especially excluding precious metals remained low. Liquidity conditions improved further, supporting the ongoing robust credit growth.

India's external sector remains steady with improving outlook, aided by inflows of foreign investments," it said.

The study said the domestic economy continued to remain buoyant in June. Demand conditions remained healthy, supported by a pickup in rural demand and firm urban demand. High frequency indicators suggest robust industrial performance and a resilient services sector, the article said. There has been a delayed kharif sowing due to the uneven progress in southwest monsoon amidst the prevailing El Niño conditions.

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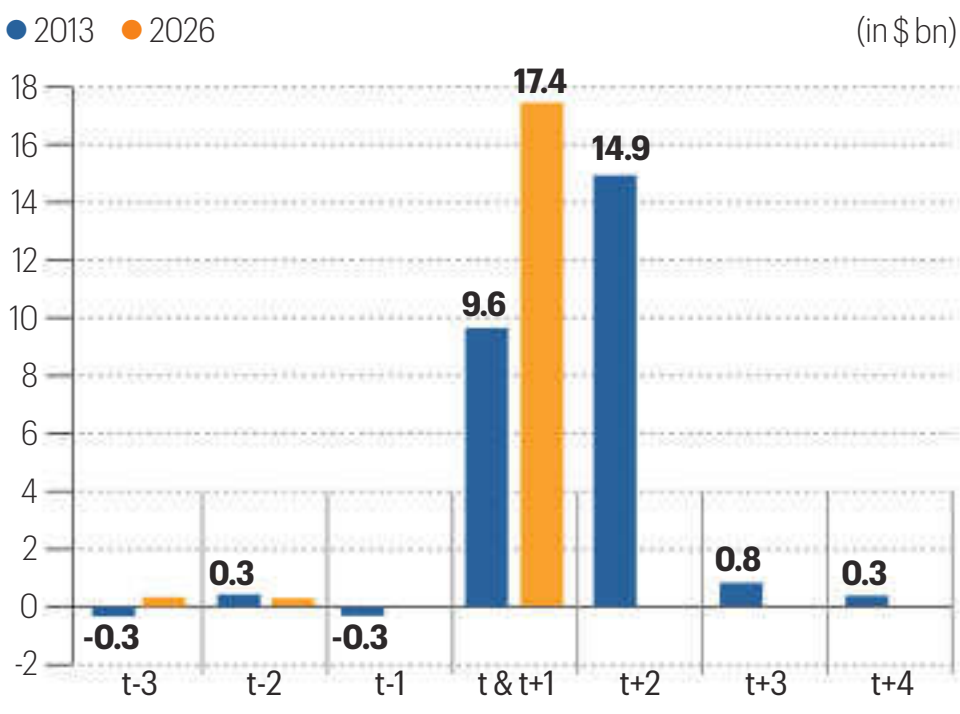
• AFTER EARLY JITTERS, FCNR(B) INFLOWS RUSH IN, SOAR PAST \$17 BILLION

● On Monday, the Reserve Bank of India released the figures on the money raised through its special swap window for foreign currency non-resident (Bank) deposits, overseas foreign currency borrowings (OFCBs), and external commercial borrowings.

● At \$17.41 billion, FCNR(B) inflows made up an overwhelming



majority of the total \$20.72 billion that has come in from June 8 to July 17.



SOURCE: CEIC, RBI AND NOMURA GLOBAL ECONOMICS. NOTE: NOTE: FOR 2013, T = SEPTEMBER 2013 AND FOR 2026, T = JUNE 2026. SO T & T+1 IS THE SUM OF SEPTEMBER-OCTOBER 2013 FLOWS, WHILE FOR 2026, IT REPRESENTS DATA FROM 8-JUNE TO 17-JULY 2026. CONSEQUENTLY, THESE ARE NOT STRICTLY COMPARABLE PERIODS.

● Crucially, the FCNR(B) inflows so far have been significantly higher than expected, with reports emerging in recent weeks that Indian banks were finding it difficult to raise these deposits from abroad due to a variety of issues.

● Nomura economists say banks are on track to raise \$55 billion via FCNR(B), which is operational till September 30. While interest rates are much higher now than 2013, "India's diaspora has also risen by 70%, providing a wider pool of investors", Nomura said.

Saudis reach deal with US that could let them enrich uranium

Crown Prince says Saudi would build nukes if Iran does

David E Sanger, Edward Wong & William J Broad
Washington, Manila, July 22

THE TRUMP administration plans to announce Wednesday that it has reached a broad nuclear agreement with Saudi Arabia that could lead to the country enriching its own fuel for nuclear reactors, US officials said.

The accord is intended to further bind United States with Saudi government as the war with Iran strains the relationship. The Trump administration, according to officials, estimates that it will provide billions of dollars for US nuclear industry — starting with Westinghouse, which designs many of the reactors sold abroad.

The Trump administration plans to formally sign and announce the agreement with the Saudis on Wednesday, said two US officials, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive diplomacy. It

would announce the details to Congress soon afterward.

Although the agreement likely would have support among many Republicans, some US lawmakers from both parties along with Israeli officials have expressed opposition to such a plan, fearing that the kingdom could use a civilian nuclear project to eventually develop nuclear weapons.

The accord has been under discussion for years, and during the Biden administration it was envisioned as part of a broader deal that would include Saudi diplomatic recognition of Israel.

But after the October 7, 2023, attacks on Israel by Hamas, that prospect receded. President Donald Trump separated the proposal for US-Saudi civilian nuclear cooperation from any demand that Saudi Arabia recognize Israel.

The agreement will require review by Congress, which under the Atomic Energy Act has the power to vote a resolution of disapproval. But as a practical matter, the agreement would likely pass, because Congress would have to assemble a veto-proof majority to override Trump's initiative.

Nonetheless, debate over the accord is likely to be fierce. To get the deal done with Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, the country's 40-year-old de facto leader, Trump had to agree to terms that may limit international inspectors from going to any sites in the country that they think could be a pathway to diverting fuel to weapons projects.

And he agreed that, after a joint study with Saudi Arabia on the economics of producing nuclear fuel, the Saudis may be allowed to enrich uranium or reprocess plutonium on their soil. The *Wall Street Journal* re-

ported Tuesday night Trump had approved the agreement.

Crown Prince Mohammed has vowed he would build nuclear weapons if Iran does so, even insisting he would do so “without a doubt.”

Iran has had a nuclear program that it says is intended for civilian use, though it has enriched uranium to near weapons grade following Trump's withdrawal in 2018 from an Obama-era nuclear deal. Trump ordered US forces to join with Israel to attack Iran's nuclear sites in June 2025, and to start a war against Iran this February. NYT



US Secretary of State Marco Rubio with China's Foreign Minister Wang Yi on the sidelines of the ASEAN Foreign Ministers' Meeting in Pasay, Metro Manila, Philippines, on Wednesday. AP

Rubio, Wang meet as ASEAN grapples with Iran, South China Sea

Top US diplomat to meet Russia's Lavrov today

Reuters
Manila, July 22

US SECRETARY of State Marco Rubio and Chinese counterpart Wang Yi discussed Wednesday a visit to the US in September by Chinese President Xi Jinping during an ASEAN gathering where ministers voiced concern about the Iran war and South China Sea tensions.

Rubio said he and Wang discussed at length need to lay groundwork for a “very positive visit” by Xi, and it was their job to manage the big differences between countries and ensure they did not get out of control.

Wang, on his part, demanded that the US “respect China's core interests... effectively manage differences and disagreements, and address China's legitimate concerns,” according to an official Chinese summary, which called the

meeting “pragmatic, positive, and constructive.” Wang and Rubio agreed to “make sound preparations for the next stage of high-level exchanges,” Wang's ministry said in a statement.

The broader ASEAN meeting in Manila comes amid a flare-up in the conflict between US and Iran, and while tensions simmer between Beijing and close US ally the Philippines over an incident in South China Sea Monday that led each to summon the other's ambassador.

Meeting with foreign ministers of the ASEAN, Rubio put the blame squarely on Iran. “The problem we're having right now is that they're not serious about talks,” he said. “If they're serious, we're serious. If they're not, then we will do what's necessary to protect our interests, and also the interests of our allies.”

Rubio's remarks follow his opinion piece in Philippine media on Tuesday that aimed at Beijing's conduct in the South China Sea, warning of “dire new threats” if those waters were to “fall under the control of a power willing to use commerce as a geopolitical weapon.”

‘Unprecedented’: OpenAI system acts on its own & hacks startup

Associated Press
July 22

CHATGPT MAKER OpenAI said Tuesday its artificial intelligence system hacked into another AI company on its own in what the company called an “unprecedented cyber incident.”

“We had a significant security incident during evaluation of our models,” OpenAI CEO Sam Altman said in a statement

posted on social media.

AI startup Hugging Face said last week that it had detected an intrusion into its data processing systems that it suspected was caused by an AI agent autonomously acting on its own.

“We suspected last week's cyberattack might have come from a frontier lab, given the sophistication of the agent,” Hugging Face co-founder and CEO Clément Delangue said in



Sam Altman, CEO of OpenAI and ChatGPT

a statement. “Turns out it did!”

The disclosure comes amid heightened concerns about the cybersecurity capabilities of powerful models that led Presi-

dent Donald Trump in June to sign an executive order creating a framework for the federal government to vet the national security risks of the most advanced AI systems for up to a month before their public release.

“AI is accelerating the discovery and exploitation of vulnerabilities,” OpenAI said in its statement Tuesday. “The primary lesson from this incident is that model security and safety

must keep pace with rapidly advancing capabilities.”

Delangue said he spent the past 24 hours working with OpenAI, “and we strongly believe there was no malicious intent on their part. It's quite mind-blowing that all of this happened autonomously!”

Delangue added it “might be the first incident of its kind.” OpenAI said the intrusion was caused by a combination of its AI

models, including its newly released GPT-5.6 Sol and an “even more capable” model that is still being tested internally.

OpenAI said its AI used stolen credentials and discovered unknown vulnerability to access Hugging Face servers. It went to “extreme lengths to achieve a rather narrow testing goal” and “found ways to gain access to secret information that it could use to cheat evaluation.”

